



## “A tomb now suffices him for whom the whole world was not sufficient”

SAID OF ALEXANDER AFTER DEATH

the eldest son and the king had several wives. There were rumors that Alexander's mother, Olympias, tried to have Philip assassinated before a son by another wife could grow old enough to succeed him. Alexander certainly acted ruthlessly to secure the succession once his father was dead, killing anybody at court who threatened his authority.

### Heroic ambitions

When, in 334 BCE, Alexander led his army across the Hellespont—the body of water that separates Europe from Asia Minor to liberate the Greek cities under Persian rule in Asia Minor, he was fulfilling a plan previously announced by his father. But the astounding campaign of conquest that followed was entirely the expression of his own ambition. Alexander claimed descent in his father's line from the Greek hero-god Herakles (Hercules) and through his mother from the legendary hero of the Trojan War, Achilles. One of his first acts on crossing to Asia Minor was to visit the site of Troy as an act of homage to his ancestor. Later, in Egypt, his claims were raised a notch higher when a priest at the desert shrine of Ammon hailed him as the “son of Zeus,” the king of the Greek gods, who was believed to be an ancestor of the

Macedonian kings. Alexander's self-image as an heroic man of destiny chosen by the gods inspired his relentless drive to conquest.

### Military leader

Alexander's army served him as the dedicated followers of a great fighting man. His elite cavalry, the Companions, were a tight-knit group with whom he fought, ate, and drank as the first among equals. On the battlefield Alexander led from the front. He liked to spearhead the cavalry charge and was often the first to storm city walls during a siege. He could be supremely reckless of his own safety, yet he was also thoroughly professional in organizing and motivating his cavalry and infantry in battle. His decisive victories over numerically superior Persian armies at Issus and Gaugamela showed a shrewd eye for the weaknesses of an apparently

### Birthplace of an icon

The Macedonians originated as hill tribesmen in the mountains of northern Greece, although Alexander was born on the coastal plain, at Pella, where his royal predecessors had established their capital.

powerful enemy as well as an instinct for gambling on aggression. It was typical of Alexander's unrelenting ambition that the conquest of the mighty Persian Empire, achieved by 330 BCE, brought no end to his campaigning. He went on fighting, not just enforcing his claim to rule all the Persian domains, but also pushing farther into India.

### Persian influence

Alexander saw himself as spreading Greek civilization by the sword. He founded Greek cities, the most famous of which was Alexandria in Egypt, and sought to Hellenize—to make Greek—the Persians whom he conquered. But his adoption of the mantle of the Persian Empire created great strains with his Macedonian followers. The

traditions of Persian court ceremony were alien to Macedonians. The Macedonian veterans were also jealous when new Persian followers found favor with Alexander. Discontent came to a head in a series of mutinies that Alexander violently suppressed.

### Noble savage

His fame in antiquity was unequaled, yet he left no creative legacy. Alexander was a ruthless man who killed both in anger and in cold blood. After Alexander died at the age of 32, his mummified body was taken to Egypt, where it remained on display for more than 500 years.



### Alexandria's lighthouse

Alexander founded Alexandria as a Macedonian capital for Egypt. Its lighthouse was one of the seven wonders of the ancient world.



ALEXANDER IDEALIZED

### TIMELINE

- **July 356 BCE** Born in Pella, Macedonia, the son of Macedon's ruler, Philip II, and his fourth wife Olympias.
- **343 BCE** The Greek philosopher Aristotle is brought to Macedon to educate him.
- **338 BCE** Plays a leading role in the defeat of Athens and Thebes at the battle of Chaeronea. His father makes himself leader of all the Greek city states except Sparta.
- **337 BCE** Philip marries a Macedonian woman, Eurydice. She bears him a son who could threaten Alexander's claim to inherit the throne.
- **336 BCE** Philip is assassinated by a bodyguard, Pausanias. Alexander succeeds to the throne and has Attalus, the chief supporter of Eurydice, killed.
- **334 BCE** Crosses the Hellespont at the head of an allied army. He visits the site of Troy and then conquers western Asia Minor, defeating a Persian army at Granicus.
- **November 333 BCE** Defeats Persian King Darius III at Issus in modern Syria, but the Persian ruler escapes.
- **332 BCE** Takes the cities of Tyre (Lebanon) and Gaza (Israel) after sieges. He proceeds to Egypt and is hailed as pharaoh. He visits the oracle of the god Zeus-Ammon at the Siwa Oasis and founds the city of Alexandria.
- **October 331 BCE** After a long march east from Egypt, he encounters the Persian army at Gaugamela. The Persians are utterly defeated and Darius flees for his life.
- **330 BCE** Darius is murdered by his Bactrian entourage. Alexander establishes himself as successor to the Persian throne. He suppresses a conspiracy in his army; his second-in-command Parmenion is among those put to death.
- **328 BCE** Falling into a rage during a drunken banquet, Alexander kills Clitus the Black, one of his leading Macedonian officers.
- **327 BCE** Marries Roxana (Roxanne), a Sogdian princess. He bloodily suppresses a conspiracy by his royal pages, who oppose his adoption of Persian customs.
- **326 BCE** After invading the Punjab, he defeats King Porus at the battle of the Hydaspes. His beloved horse Bucephalus is killed. Reaching the Hyphasis River his soldiers mutiny and force Alexander to turn back, following the Jhelum, a tributary of the Indus River, to the sea.
- **326 BCE** He leads part of his army back to Persia in a march across the Gedrosian Desert that costs many soldiers their lives.
- **324 BCE** The Macedonians in Alexander's army mutiny as he recruits increasing numbers of Persians. Many Macedonian veterans are discharged. Alexander is plunged in deep grief when his closest friend, and rumored lover, Hephaestion dies.
- **June 11, 323 BCE** Alexander dies of a fever in Babylon, leaving no clear successor.

### HOW WE KNOW

#### LIVING GOD

This silver coin shows Alexander as the semidivine Herakles, distinguished by his lionskin cap. On other coins he is represented as the horned god Ammon, the supreme Egyptian deity. Alexander's close association with the gods and a suggested direct paternal link to Herakles, rather than Philip, enforced his own sense of destiny. According to one written source, Alexander attended banquets in Persia dressed as gods. The myth of his divinity was widely accepted and shrines were raised in his name.

ALEXANDER AS HERAKLES

